

Prepare for the unexpected

Build a Business Continuity Plan



Small
Business
Commissioner

smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge and pay our respect to the traditional custodians of the lands and waters of NSW, and all Aboriginal Elders, past, present, and emerging.



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Introduction

Every business should have a Business Continuity Plan. No business is immune to the risks of disruption or interruption. Nobody thinks an emergency event will happen to them, but preparing your business to survive such an event is vital for every business owner.

This Business Continuity Plan will guide you through the essential steps. It could mean the difference between a business resuming quickly after an interruption or not reopening at all.

A Business Continuity Plan should outline strategies for keeping your business operational despite unexpected events such as staff illness, extreme weather events, power outages, pandemics, cyber-attacks and other crimes. Not every event is an emergency, and all can disrupt your ability to operate.

Prepare for the Unexpected expands on the five-step plan outlined in our *Get Ready Business* guide and will help you to know your risk, plan now for what you will do and get your business ready in more detail.



KNOW YOUR RISKS

Identify the types of disruptions that your business might face. If you're new to the area, it's really important to understand how you might be at risk so you can know what to expect.



PLAN NOW FOR WHAT YOU WILL DO

Sit down with your staff and use this step to **make an emergency action plan** so that everyone knows what needs to be done and by whom.



GET YOUR BUSINESS READY

There are some really practical and easy actions you can take now to **prepare your business and plan for business continuity**.



BE AWARE

If a disaster does strike, knowing where to look for reliable, up-to-date information could help save you vital time. **Connect with key information sources** now to receive regular alerts.



LOOK OUT FOR EACH OTHER

Neighbouring businesses can be one of the best sources of information and help before, during and after a disaster. **Develop connections with local businesses** and commit to helping one another.

How to use this document

- Complete the templates and checklists in sections 1 and 2 to create your Business Continuity Plan.
- Use sections 3 and 4 to be aware of the signals of an impending disaster and to connect with local businesses so you can look out for each other.
- Refer to section 5 for checklists specifically for bushfires, floods, storms, structure fires, tsunamis and pandemics.
- Refer to section 6 for recovery checklists to assist you with recovery and reopening your business.
- Keep your plan safe, ideally in your emergency essentials kit.
- Make a copy of your plan and store it in the Cloud.
- Review, update and practice it at least once a year.

Other resources

For support in recovering from a business disruption or interruption, see the *Get Ready Business* suite of resources, including *Get Back to Business* and *Insurance Claims for Small Business* at smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/help/common-questions/get-ready-for-disasters



1. Know your risks

To develop a Business Continuity Plan you first need to know the risks your business is likely to face. Regardless of your location, all businesses are at risk of disruptions and interruptions.

Complete the Know your risks checklist by:

1. Ticking the box if the potential disruption is a risk to your business.
2. Rating the level of risk from either 1 (no risk) to 5 (very high risk).
3. Indicating yes or no if a plan is already in place to address this risk.
4. Indicating yes or no if the potential disruption would have an immediate effect on earnings.
5. Risks that can affect all businesses include:
 - structure fires
 - bushfires
 - floods
 - storms
 - tsunamis
 - coastal erosion and landslides
 - epidemics or pandemics
 - earthquakes
 - droughts
 - heatwaves
 - infrastructure or power failure (e.g. utility failure knocks out internet, NBN, phone, EFTPOS systems)
 - human error (e.g. explosion, mechanical breakdowns, technical failure)
 - crime-related disaster events (e.g. cyber-attack, fraud, theft, terrorist threat, bomb blast)
 - unexpected illness or absence of you or key staff members

There are specific checklists for bushfires, floods, storms, structure fires, pandemics and tsunamis from page 31 to assist you.

TIP: Talk with **neighbouring businesses**, a **business advisor** and your **local council** about any potential risks in your area and what you should do to prepare.

Connect with local Emergency Services or visit the following websites to learn more about preparing for specific hazards:

- NSW Rural Fire Service (RFS) for bushfires rfs.nsw.gov.au
- NSW State Emergency Service (NSW SES) for floods, storms and tsunamis ses.nsw.gov.au
- Fire and Rescue NSW (FRNSW) for structural urban fires and HAZMAT (hazardous materials) incidents fire.nsw.gov.au
- NSW Police Force for crime-related events such as shoplifting, break-ins, fraud and robbery police.nsw.gov.au
- Bureau of Meteorology (BOM) for information on weather forecasts and severe weather warnings bom.gov.au
- NSW Health for heatwave information and support health.nsw.gov.au/environment/beattheheat

Dial Triple Zero (000) for Police, Fire or Ambulance for life-threatening emergencies. Visit triplezero.gov.au for more information. If you are deaf or have a speech or hearing impairment dial **106** for the Text Emergency Relay Service.

1.1 Know your risks

Fill out the table below to assess risks to your business. For the risk rating, '1' is low likelihood and/or low impact, and '5' is very high likelihood and/or high impact. **If you rate a risk as a 5, this needs immediate attention and action.**

Potential disruption	Is this a risk for my business?	The risk rating is:	Do I have a plan already in place?	Will this affect immediate earnings?
Buildings				
No access to business premises	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Damage to business premises	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Fault with utilities (water, gas, sewerage)	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Major power outage	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Stock and equipment				
Loss of stock	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of key equipment	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Data and information				
No access to phone networks	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
No access to internet	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of data or key documents	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
People				
Loss of key staff due to illness or skills shortage	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Owner affected by health or personal issues	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Legal issues	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of suppliers	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of customers	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of customers' access to business via phone/online	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Major building works, road closures or other local events	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Loss of reputation (if business is not operational within a few days of disaster)	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Environmental				
Business is near a river	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Business is near bushland	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Business is near the coast	☐		☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No

2. Business continuity templates

Plan now for what you will do and get your business ready

Knowing how to take the appropriate action could help save your life, the lives of your staff and the future of your business. You can take some practical and easy actions now to prepare your business and plan for business continuity.

Go through these easy-to-follow templates and checklists and decide who will be responsible for each part of the plan to ensure your business remains resilient despite a disruption. Fill out the sections to complete all the key information you will need for your Business Continuity Plan.

Business continuity templates

- | | | | | | |
|-----|---|--|------|---|---|
| 2.1 |  | Emergency essentials kit | 2.8 |  | Plan an alternative operation location |
| 2.2 |  | Plan how you will move stock, equipment and fixtures | 2.9 |  | Plan an alternative supply chain |
| 2.3 |  | Protect your property | 2.10 |  | Plan methods to maintain customer relations |
| 2.4 |  | Develop an insurance plan | 2.11 |  | Plan for how you will safeguard all other critical business areas |
| 2.5 |  | Develop a finance plan | 2.12 |  | Train staff for business continuity |
| 2.6 |  | Prepare your emergency plan | 2.13 |  | Conduct general premises maintenance |
| 2.7 |  | Back up data to the Cloud | | | |

TIPS for creating your plan:

- Think about the location and nature of your business and how this might impact the actions you need to take (e.g. located on the second floor or near power lines).
- Ensure that more than one staff member is trained to complete an action to avoid the risk of relying too heavily on one person.
- Develop your plan with any staff, so that they feel a part of the process.
- Test and refine the plan with feedback from your staff.
- Ensure all new staff are given an induction to the emergency plan (2.6) within their first week.



2.1 Emergency essentials kit

Preserve your most important documents and items that are too important to lose.

Who is responsible		Where it will be stored:	
Name:			
Signed:		Date:	

How you can do it
☐ You will need a water or fire-proof pack to hold all your documents and a bag big enough to hold this pack with all your essential business items.
☐ Store this kit in an easy-to-access location at your business.
☐ Back up all your important documents in Cloud storage.

To be added to emergency essentials kit on the day of disaster
☐ Any cash on site
☐ Portable electronic devices
☐ Keys
☐ Other
☐ Other
☐ Other

Things to keep in mind
☐ Make a copy of your documents to keep off-site as access to internet may be unavailable for some time.
☐ Take photos of the property.

To always be stored in emergency essentials kit
☐ Business registration documents
☐ Licences, certificates, awards
☐ Insurance policy agreements
☐ Emergency action plan
☐ Neighbour contact information
☐ Important contact information (staff emergency contacts, suppliers, customers etc.)
☐ Important contracts and bank loan documents
☐ Title deeds to property or copy of the lease for the premises
☐ Contact details for your landlord and/or their agent



2.2 Plan how you will move stock, equipment and fixtures



Being able to move your fixtures and stock in a hurry will save you precious time.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Speak with neighbouring businesses about the measures they have in place to move fixtures and stock quickly.
Signed:	Date:	
Things to keep in mind		☐ Other businesses in your local Business Chamber may also have good suggestions.
☐ Ask your local Council about the maximum height of potential floodwaters that may impact your property so you can design storage solutions above this height.		☐ Explore inventive storage solutions online to see if any suit your business needs.
☐ Check your lease agreement for information about the responsibility and process for urgent repairs in the event of damage to a premises. For example, there can be different arrangements for fittings, fixtures and structural elements of the building. See www.nsw.gov.au/emergency/recovery/retail-and-commercial-leasing-rights		☐ Decide now where you will move your stock/equipment to save them.
		☐ Consider high positioning on site or an alternative offsite location.
Stock and equipment will be moved to these locations:		
Stock or equipment	Location	



2.3 Protect your property

Disruptions and interruptions can impact your business from multiple locations and in different ways. Protect your business by fortifying entry points and securing internal premises. Depending on the threat, you will need to take different protective measures.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Take steps to protect the inside of your business to help minimise the rebuild cost/effort (e.g. move shelving, lay plastic sheeting).
Signed:	Date:	☐ Discuss the different approaches you will take with staff.
Things to keep in mind		☐ Ensure you have the resources required to protect your business prior to threats.
☐ If replacing property, investigate fire-proof and waterproof alternatives. For example, in some flood-prone areas, retractable shelving and waterproof, easily liftable floor coverings can be installed. They can be quickly removed if a flood is coming, and quickly restored to position afterwards.		☐ Think about any external elements of your business that could cause damage in a disaster and how to fortify them (e.g. sandbags, boarding up).
☐ Sandbagging drains, sinks and toilets can reduce the back-flow of water into your business.		☐ Plan now for how you will minimise the threat of damage to or damage from external fixtures (e.g. signs, stands, tables, chairs, umbrellas, bikes).
☐ If considering non-urgent repairs to a premises, contact your landlord to agree on the best way forward before undertaking any works.		☐ Plan to turn off electricity, gas and water at the mains.

External fixtures and how each item will be secured:	
List of external fixtures	How each item will be secured



2.4 Develop a finance plan

If disruptions happen, you need to be able to easily access all your financial and business records, pay your bills, invoice your customers, and have sufficient resources and cash flow to continue operating your business.

Who is responsible		Things to keep in mind
Name:		☐ You are responsible for keeping required business records.
Signed:	Date:	☐ To continue operating your business, you may need to be able to access your accounts system, including sales and invoices, from another device and location.
How you can do it		☐ If you or the person who handles your business accounts is unable to work for a period of time, you need a back-up plan for who will continue to operate your day-to-day business finance activities such as paying and issuing invoices.
☐ Speak to your accountant or financial advisors about: • Checking how your business' financial records are currently managed and stored, including steps to safely back up and store financial records in the Cloud. • Developing a financial plan for how the business will operate in case of disruption or interruption. • Ensuring that your business will have sufficient cash flow and financial resources to operate. • The way forward, if the event negatively impacts your business for an extended period of time.		☐ You have a legal obligation to ensure that your business does not trade whilst insolvent, i.e. when it is unable to pay debt(s) as and when they fall due. Some signs that your business may be starting to experience difficulties are: • suppliers are requiring cash payments • you are struggling to pay your bills, employees and rent on time • you are putting your own money into the business to pay bills • you are unable to provide for employee leave and entitlements • your cash flow is negative • your customers are paying late • you are not keeping up with invoicing your customers.
☐ If your business is starting to experience any cash flow difficulties it is important to seek professional advice as soon as possible. The earlier you do, the more options are available.		☐ If you are unable to meet your existing financial obligations for a period of time, due to disruptions or interruptions or a major change in your circumstances, act early: speak to your accountant or qualified financial counsellor and contact the financial hardship team at your bank/lender. You may be eligible for repayment relief while you get your business back up and running. You may also be eligible for financial relief from ongoing commitments like taxation, council rates, energy and water bills, phone/internet bills, and insurance premiums.
		☐ If your request for hardship assistance has been denied by your bank or lender, you can contact the Small Business Debt Helpline for free financial counselling. Visit sbdh.org.au or call 1800 413 828 . Alternatively, the Australian Financial Complaints Authority may be able to assist with complaints from small businesses with loan facilities of less than \$5 million. Visit afca.org.au or call 1800 931 678 .

For more information, please see:

<https://www.smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/help/common-questions/experiencing-financial-hardship-where-to-get-help>



2.5 Develop an insurance plan

When disruptions happen, the costs of repairs coupled with ever-mounting fixed costs can be staggering. Insuring your business is critical to protecting your business' future.

Who is responsible	
Name:	
Signed:	Date:

How you can do it
☐ There are several types of insurance to consider, not just disaster protection (e.g. business disruption insurance). The first step to determining what cover you need is to establish what your business relies upon in order to generate revenue. Then determine what likely event could occur that will stop or disrupt those activities.
☐ If you cannot get insurance, you need to create financial reserves that would help to cover costs if anything were to happen.
☐ There are resources available to help you find cover online. It may also help to talk to an insurance broker to discuss your business risks and understand your options. For more information, visit: • Understand Insurance understandinsurance.com.au • Insurance Council of Australia insurancecouncil.com.au/find-an-insurer/ • National Insurance Brokers Association needabroker.com.au or 1300 531 073

Things to keep in mind
☐ Make sure you have enough of the right insurance in place to cover you against your biggest risks and protect your assets: • Income protection insurance • Business interruption insurance, including options for loss of attraction, utilities disruption and loss of access • Building or contents insurance • Vehicle insurance • Cyber insurance.
☐ Your insurance policy is your contract with the insurer. It states when, how and what the insurer must pay for. Make sure you understand any particular requirements and exclusions under your policy. For example, some policies will pay for damage caused by rainwater or stormwater, but not for damage caused by floodwater. Make sure you read the fine print.
☐ Find out if your policy includes any coverage of secondary impacts, such as the cost of business relocation or temporary accommodation.
☐ Read the Insurance Claims for Small Business guide which will help you through the claims process. Visit: smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/resources/guides/guide-making-insurance-claims



Insurance policies template

Insurance contract 1

Insurance type	
Insurer and policy number	
What's covered	
What's not covered	
Insurance company contract	
Expiry date	
Amount paid and how often	

Insurance contract 2

Insurance type	
Insurer and policy number	
What's covered	
What's not covered	
Insurance company contract	
Expiry date	
Amount paid and how often	

Insurance contract 3

Insurance type	
Insurer and policy number	
What's covered	
What's not covered	
Insurance company contract	
Expiry date	
Amount paid and how often	



2.6 Prepare your emergency plan

Every business must have an emergency plan for evacuating the premises to ensure that people are safe.

Who is responsible	
Name:	
Signed:	Date:

Things to keep in mind
☐ Every year hundreds of businesses succumb to structure fires that are nothing to do with bushfires, floods or major weather events, and many of these businesses cease trading as a result. Australian Standard AS3745 Planning for Emergencies in Facilities (access at: www.standards.org.au) is designed to enhance the safety of people in facilities, by providing a framework for emergency planning.
☐ Evacuation routes may already be identified and time-lined for your area by the NSW SES.
☐ There may be little or no warning to tell you when to put your plans into action, so it is important to monitor weather situations at all times and act quickly. Do not wait to be told to act.
☐ Follow social media pages for emergency services or download the official emergency apps. Some agencies have distribution lists for their warnings.
☐ Know where the nearest medical assistance is if you need it.
☐ Be mindful of the mix of people in your workplace, e.g. number of casual staff, visitors, staff who often travel or work in other locations.
☐ Allow staff to leave early in the event of a disaster if they need to.
☐ Review or test your contacts list regularly to make sure it is up-to-date, e.g. send a message to all staff asking them to respond. Follow up with those who do not respond in case their contact details have changed.

How you can do it
☐ Plan now for how you will be evacuating depending on the situation you face. The types of emergencies to plan for should include: fire, explosion, medical emergency, rescues, hazard chemical incidents, bomb threats, armed confrontations and natural hazards.
☐ When preparing emergency plans for your business refer to AS3745. Your emergency plan should provide for any staff: • Contact details of fire wardens, floor wardens and first aid officers • Contact details for local emergency services and the poisons centre • Guidance on how staff will become alerted to an emergency e.g. siren, phone, SMS • A map locating fire protection equipment, emergency exits and assembly points.
☐ Your emergency plan needs to cover: • Emergency procedures – including procedures for evacuation, for getting medical treatment and assistance, for contacting emergency services, and effective communication procedures between the person authorised to coordinate the emergency response and everyone else in the workplace • Testing of the emergency procedures – including how often they are tested • Information and training – for workers on how the emergency procedures are implemented • A list of who to contact – in the event of an emergency or business disruption. This includes all staff contact numbers and each of their emergency contacts.
☐ Place emergency plans and procedures in easy-to-access and visible places e.g. common areas and in work vehicles for staff whose work includes travel.
☐ Connect with neighbours before, during and after an event. You may need to rely on each other for help.

Emergency plan: who to contact

Fill in the gaps to complete your Emergency Contacts list

Emergency	Triple Zero (000) Police, Fire or Ambulance	
Weather warnings	Bureau of Meteorology – bom.gov.au/nsw ABC News – abc.net.au/news/emergency	
Storm, flood, tsunami	NSW State Emergency Service – 132 500 , ses.nsw.gov.au	
Fire (non-emergency)	For building and structure fires – Fire and Rescue NSW, fire.nsw.gov.au For Bushfires and rural fire districts – NSW Rural Fire Service, rfs.nsw.gov.au	
Police (non-emergency)	NSW Police – 131 444 , police.nsw.gov.au Crime Stoppers – 1800 333 000 , crimestoppers.com.au Local Police station:	
Medical (non-emergency)	Healthdirect Australia – 1800 022 222 , healthdirect.gov.au Ambulance Service of NSW – ambulance.nsw.gov.au	
Landlord/building manager		
Utilities	Water:	Ph:
	Electricity:	Ph:
	Gas:	Ph:
Poisons information centre	Poison Information Hotline – 13 11 26 , poisonsinfo.nsw.gov.au	
Live traffic updates & incidents	Report a traffic incident – 131 700 Live Traffic NSW – livetraffic.com	
Power outages (network lines)	You can either contact your own retailer (the one that bills your business) or the distributor for your area (which can also be found on your bill or by contacting your retailer). In NSW there are three energy distributors, each is responsible for a geographic region of NSW. • Ausgrid – 13 13 88, ausgrid.com.au • Endeavour Energy – 131 003, endeavourenergy.com.au • Essential Energy – 13 20 80, essentialenergy.com.au	
Biosecurity	Biosecurity – 1800 680 244	
Telecommunications (faults, damage or hazards)	Telstra – 13 22 03 Optus – 1800 505 777 Other:	
Local council	Name:	Ph:

Emergency plan: evacuation procedures

Bushfire	If there is a bushfire in your area, leaving early is the safest option	
When will you evacuate?		
If you are leaving early, what will trigger your decision to leave?		
Don't wait for an official warning to leave.		
Where are you evacuating to?		
Have an alternate evacuation route in the case of fallen trees or active fire preventing your exit. In which direction is the fire moving?		
Do you know where the nearest Neighbourhood Safer Place is? (Find out on the NSW RFS website) rfs.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/neighbourhood-safer-places		
How will you transport evacuees?		
Do you have employees with special mobility requirements?		
How will you transport pets and animals?		

Structure fire		
When will you evacuate?		
Where are you evacuating to?		
How will you transport evacuees?		

Severe weather		
When will you evacuate?		
Where are you evacuating to?		
How will you transport evacuees?		

Flood	Turn off electricity, gas and water at the mains in the event of a flood.	
When will you evacuate?		
Where are you evacuating to?		
How will you transport evacuees?		

Chemical incident

When will you evacuate?	
Where are you evacuating to?	
How will you transport evacuees?	

Other (please specify):

When will you evacuate?	
Where are you evacuating to?	
How will you transport evacuees?	

Emergency plan: staff emergency contacts list

Staff member's name	Job title (include any emergency team role e.g. first aid officer, fire warden)	Contact details (home phone, mobile, email)	Staff member's emergency contact (i.e. their next of kin or emergency contact)
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:
		Ph: Email:	Ph: Email:



2.7 Back up data to the Cloud

A disruption can destroy physical documents and/or computers within minutes. You may have no time to enter or remain in your business to gather essential records (e.g. client lists, schedules, invoices, blueprints, maps).

Cloud-based storage allows you to access your key data and documents from any location with an internet connection, even if you no longer have physical access to your business or if your computer was destroyed.

Who is responsible	
Name:	
Signed:	Date:

Things to keep in mind
☐ Make sure your mobile phone is fully charged and have a charged power pack as a backup.
☐ Keep a power cord/charger handy in case power is available and you need to recharge.
☐ Banking and electronic purchasing services may not be available during emergencies.
☐ For your IT passwords, use a catchphrase or passphrase, rather than just a password. Or use a password management system. Single word and number combinations can be easy to guess.
☐ Business owners have a legal responsibility to keep business and customer information safe. The Australian Cyber Security Centre (ACSC) can help small businesses respond to cyber security incidents. Reporting cyber security incidents ensures that the ACSC can provide timely assistance. To report a cybercrime or cyber security incident, visit cyber.gov.au

How you can do it
☐ Explore Cloud storage options online or with your IT consultant to see which one suits your business (examples of Cloud-based storage include Dropbox, iCloud, Box, Google Drive, Nextcloud).
☐ Set up a regular backup process. Keep a hard-copy backup of important documents as NBN/internet access may be compromised during disasters.
☐ Include a battery powered radio in your emergency essentials kit.
☐ Explore options for backup power (e.g. generator) if power is critical to your business operations.
☐ Consider whether cyber insurance would be beneficial for your business.
☐ Move your corporate emails to a Cloud-based email service.
☐ Make sure your software applications are kept up-to-date by enabling automatic updates to install latest security patches.
☐ Install security software to prevent unauthorised connections and scan regularly for malware.
☐ ACSC provides trusted and relevant information on how small businesses can protect themselves from the most common cyber security threats. ACSC has developed a <i>Small Business Cyber Security Guide</i> and a <i>Small Business Cyber Security checklist</i> to help small businesses understand, take action, and increase cyber security resilience against ever-evolving cyber security threats. For more information, visit cyber.gov.au/resources-business-and-government/essential-cyber-security/small-business-cybersecurity

Data backup plan

Data to be regularly backed up (e.g. payroll, client lists, supplier lists)

1.	5.
2.	6.
3.	7.
4.	8.

Storage location(s) for back-ups (e.g. Cloud, home safe, etc.)

--

Steps to complete backup (if not automatic)

1.	5.
2.	6.
3.	7.
4.	8.

Frequency for back-ups (daily/weekly/monthly)

--

Person(s) responsible (who will ensure regular backups occur and who can access the stored data?)

Name 1:

Name 2:



2.8 Plan an alternative operation location

If you are evacuated or suddenly unable to access your usual business premises, you will need an alternative site (or sites) arranged so you can continue to operate.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Identify other off-site areas where you might operate your business from (e.g. from home, garage or shed).
Signed:	Date:	☐ Consider accessing another business premise or sharing business premises.
Things to keep in mind		☐ See if you can temporarily work from a hub, co-working space or warehouse.
☐ Consider how long it will take to get your business set up in an alternative location.		☐ Put measures in place to allow employees (if any) to work remotely (e.g. video conferencing) where possible.
☐ Consider whether the site is going to be suitable and accessible during an emergency.		☐ Use your webpage (or other online sales platform) for online sales or home deliveries.
☐ Ensure you will have what you need to run your business, e.g. power, running water, internet.		

Alternative location for this business

Location (including address)

What services, equipment and supplies are already in place at the alternative location?	
1.	4.
2.	5.
3.	6.

What more will you need at the location to continue to operate your business?	
Additional needs	How will they be acquired or transported?
1.	
2.	
3.	



2.9 Plan an alternative supply chain

You may be unable to source stock to run your business if a disruption negatively impacts one of your suppliers, their access to your property or the transport networks between you.

Who is responsible?	
Name:	
Signed:	Date:

Things to keep in mind	How you can do it
☐ Review this list often (e.g. yearly) and update any contact details that may have changed.	☐ Make a list of the other supplier options you could call on if such a disruption occurred.

Alternative supplier list

What services, equipment and supplies are already in place at the alternative location?			
Supplied items / existing supplier	Contact details	Alternative supplier	Contact details of alternative supplier
Item:	Ph:	Business name:	Ph:
Business name and contact person:	Email:	Contact person:	Email:
Item:	Ph:	Business name:	Ph:
Business name and contact person:	Email:	Contact person:	Email:
Item:	Ph:	Business name:	Ph:
Business name and contact person:	Email:	Contact person:	Email:
Item:	Ph:	Business name:	Ph:
Business name and contact person:	Email:	Contact person:	Email:



2.10 Plan methods to maintain customer relations

If your business cannot operate in its usual location or even operate at all, it is important to maintain customer relations to ensure your business remains their vendor/supplier of choice.

Making efforts to communicate with customers during this time and reminding them of how much you value them could help to maintain customer loyalty.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Set up a website and social media if your business is not already online.
Signed:	Date:	☐ Develop channels of communication now (e.g. social media, email lists) that do not require a face-to-face presence, so that they are possible avenues of communication during and post-disaster.
Things to keep in mind		☐ Make a list of key business contacts (e.g. suppliers, customers, clients, staff, your bank, Australia Post etc.).
☐ Consider and plan for your legal liability if you are unable to meet agreed deadlines or deliverables because of disruptions to your business.		☐ Set up a shared document containing important business and customer contacts in the Cloud that all staff can access and update. You may also be able to extract some contact details from your accounting software, but make sure it will be accessible in a crisis.
		☐ Stay connected to your customers during and after an emergency. Customers will need to know: • if you are still open and trading • updates on what is happening to their orders • if there have been changes to your location, services or hours of operation.
		☐ Consider using paid text message services that can send bulk updates – these may be useful for marketing or managing appointment reminders.



Key business contacts list

Who needs to know if the business has been disrupted?			
Company	Business name and main contact	Phone	Email
Accountant		Ph:	Email:
Lawyer/solicitor		Ph:	Email:
Property manager/landlord		Ph:	Email:
Bank/lender		Ph:	Email:
Insurance agent		Ph:	Email:
Electronic payment provider (e.g. for credit/debit card or online payments)		Ph:	Email:
Internet service provider		Ph:	Email:
Paid subscriptions (e.g. software, online platforms, newspapers)		Ph:	Email:
Automatic payments that need to be disabled		Ph:	Email:
Electricity		Ph:	Email:
Gas		Ph:	Email:
Water		Ph:	Email:
Other		Ph:	Email:



2.11 Plan for how you will safeguard all other critical business areas

Think about the other areas of your business that are crucial for it to operate. Plan for how you will continue these essential operations.

As the owner or manager, you need to make sure your business can continue uninterrupted if you need to step out of the business or if key staff leave or are unavailable.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Create a handover plan that includes all the key information needed to run the business effectively in your absence.
Signed:	Date:	
Things to keep in mind		☐ Treat this plan as an active document, not a static record, and encourage your staff to do the same.
☐ Place a reminder in your diary or phone to review your handover plan at least once a year to make sure it stays current.		☐ Have regular discussions as part of your business management or staff meetings.

Handover plan for this business

What services, equipment and supplies are already in place at the alternative location?	
1. Person(s) who will take over managerial duties:	
Phone:	Email:
2. Person(s) who can manage financial and legal matters (could be a Power of Attorney):	
Phone:	Email:
3. Accountant for this business:	
Phone:	Email:
4. Lawyer/solicitor for this business:	
Phone:	Email:

Handover plan for this business *continued*

What services, equipment and supplies are already in place at the alternative location?

5. Landlord/realtor for this business

Phone:

Email:

6. Rent amount: \$

☐ weekly ☐ fortnightly ☐ monthly

Paid into (account details):

Lease expiry date:

7. Spare keys and float are kept:

8. The business manual is kept:

It is also saved on the computer/Cloud in the following location:

Other security details:

9. It is also saved on the computer/Cloud in the following location:

10. These business tasks are essential to continue in my absence:

1.

4.

2.

5.

3.

6.

11. These business tasks can be left until I return:

1.

4.

2.

5.

3.

6.

12. I have income protection insurance:

☐ Yes ☐ No

Policy details:

13. Anything else that is unique to this business and required in order to continue operating it:



2.12 Train staff for business continuity

If your business is severely damaged by an emergency or disaster and cannot reopen, your staff's livelihoods are at risk.

It is also likely from time to time that staff will become unavoidably absent from your business. The absence of key staff may delay your business recovery, particularly if they are the only people with key skills or knowledge about an aspect of the business.

Who is responsible	
Name:	
Signed:	Date:

Things to keep in mind	How you can do it
☐ Staff may become affected personally by the disaster and be unable to work or assist the business.	☐ Make a list of who is trained or experienced in key knowledge areas or roles. Train additional/ multiple staff in business-critical tasks.
☐ There are several ways to train staff e.g. staff can shadow a co-worker for on-the-job training, or they can provide one another with short presentations or training sessions.	☐ Have procedures and key information outlining how to perform each job role in your business stored in a place where it can be easily accessed in an emergency (e.g. the Cloud).
☐ Staff may be able to assist by documenting what they do in their job, including any key processes, systems and contacts.	☐ Ensure staff are part of the disaster-planning process to create a sense of ownership of the business outcomes.

Key skills for business continuity

Staff training record – which staff are trained in which key processes				
Staff members	Key skills #1	Key skills #2	Key skills #3	Future training planned



2.13 Conduct general premises maintenance

Keeping on top of essential general maintenance for your premises will assist with protecting your property.

Who is responsible		How you can do it
Name:		☐ Maintain a Critical Tasks checklist and ensure items are actioned by their due date.
Signed:	Date:	
		☐ Involve staff, if appropriate, in checking the Critical Tasks checklist.
		☐ If you have a retail or commercial lease, check the terms of your lease to know your rights and obligations with regards to any general premises maintenance.

Critical tasks checklist

Task	Date last completed	Next due date
Clean gutters and install metal gutter guards		
Check wiring		
Fill any structural cracks		
Install sprinklers and/or fire extinguishers		
Trim overhanging trees and branches		
Clear underlying vegetation		
Check safety distance of trees to building		
Check walls, eaves and roofs are secure and in good repair		
Check Emergency Essentials Kit location		
Ensure any protective equipment is in good working order, including smoke alarms and batteries, fire blankets and fire extinguishers		
Ensure additional equipment is available if staying to defend against Bushfire (ladders, mops, buckets, extra-long hoses)		
Stock sandbags where flood risk is identified		
Stock clean water		
Maintain generator including fuel		
Ensure fuel is stored above flood water and away from any impact zone		
Establish safe evacuation routes and make sure staff are aware e.g. signs, maps		
Ensure clear access to electricity, gas and water mains		

3. Be aware

Being aware of the signals of an impending disruption is crucial in knowing when to act and trigger your emergency action plan, ultimately helping you to save your business.

Connect with relevant emergency services to stay up to date on disaster information in your area, including disaster preparation events.

Who to call

- Dial **000** For Emergency Assistance – Police, Fire or Ambulance, triplezero.gov.au
- Dial **106** For Police, Fire or Ambulance via the Text Emergency Relay Service for persons with speech or hearing impairment.

Emergency information

- ABC Radio frequencies – reception.abc.net.au
- ABC Emergency website for NSW – abc.net.au/news/emergency/state/nsw
- Live Traffic NSW - Transport for NSW – livetraffic.com
- For flood, storm and tsunami – NSW State Emergency Service, **132 500**, ses.nsw.gov.au
- For building and structure fires – Fire and Rescue NSW, fire.nsw.gov.au
- For bushfires – NSW Rural Fire Service, **1800 679 73**, rfs.nsw.gov.au

Smartphone apps



Emergency+



Hazards Near Me NSW



Live Traffic NSW

Additional resources

For links and resources, especially for recovering from disaster, see *Get back to business – a guide to re-covering from disaster* at smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/resources/guides/get-back-business-guide-recovering-disaster

4. Look out for each other

Neighbouring businesses can be one of the best sources of information and help before, during and after a disaster. Develop connections with local businesses and commit to helping one another.

- At times, your community may be isolated. Your local business community may be your best source of support.
- Older businesses within the community will often have greater experience of disasters and can provide you with helpful advice in preparing your business.
- Local business chambers, councils and emergency services can share information about risks and disasters in the area and help you take steps to prepare and rebuild your business.

List three neighbouring businesses that will help you if they are able and that you will help if you are able:

Contact name	Business/organisation	Phone number and email
1.		
2.		
3.		

5. Checklists

Bushfire preparation checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan to prepare your business for a bushfire.

It is important to understand the bushfire risk to your business and to prepare your business, your property and your employees.

Employers have a duty of care to employees and visitors when they are on your property or undertaking a service provided by your business. Use this checklist to help assess whether you are adequately prepared for a bushfire. See the NSW Rural Fire Service (RFS) website for further information rfs.nsw.gov.au

Know your risk

- ☐ Do you know your risk? Consider whether bushfire is a risk to your business.

Make a Bushfire Survival Plan - There are four simple steps to making a Bushfire Survival Plan for your business:

- | | | |
|--------------------------|-------------------|--|
| ☐ | 1. Discuss | Talk with your employees about what you will do if a bushfire threatens your business. |
| ☐ | 2. Prepare | Prepare your property and get it ready for bushfire season. |
| ☐ | 3. Know | See the top five actions to make your property safer below. |
| ☐ | 4. Keep | Keep all the bushfire information numbers, websites and the smartphone app handy. |

- ☐ Head to myfireplan.com.au for a step-by-step guide to making a Bushfire Survival Plan.

- ☐ Think about your insurance needs in relation to fire and make sure your chosen policy provides an appropriate level of cover for your business and that you understand any requirements. Remember that rebuilding in a Bushfire-prone area can be expensive.

- ☐ Have a plan about what to do with animals and pets.

- ☐ Evacuation plans (leaving early is the safest option): (refer to pages 15-18)

Where will you go?

What will you take?

Write the address of your nearest Neighbourhood Safer Place. Find the address at rfs.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/neighbourhood-safer-places

Infrastructure and property - Before fire season starts, prepare your property:

Top 5 actions to make your property safer. See the checklist on NSW RFS: rfs.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare

1. Trim	2. Mow	3. Remove	4. Clear	5. Prepare
----------------	---------------	------------------	-----------------	-------------------

- ☐ **Emergencies**

- To report unattended fires or in an emergency call Triple Zero (000).
- Stay updated by using Fires Near Me rfs.nsw.gov.au/fire-information/fires-near-me or download the app.
- For those who do not have internet access, the Bushfire Information Line is **1800 679 737**.
- Listen to your local ABC radio for advice.

Flood preparation checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan to prepare your business for a flood event.

Flooding can cause damage to your business assets and stock, or indirectly impact on your business activities by disrupting supply chains and customer access routes. Floods can occur rapidly and without warning.

Use this checklist to prepare your business in advance and take action to reduce potential flooding impacts. See the NSW State Emergency Service (NSW SES) website for further flood information ses.nsw.gov.au. To view all current NSW flood and weather warnings visit the Bureau of Meteorology website bom.gov.au

General

- ☐ Consider whether flood is a risk to your business. For further information on your flood risk, contact the NSW SES or your local council.
- ☐ Include risk mitigation strategies for flood in your Business Continuity Plan. General information relating to preparing for flood, storm and tsunami events can be accessed on the NSW SES website ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare. Further information specific to businesses can also be found at ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/business-emergency-planning.
- ☐ Consider your insurance needs in relation to flood and make sure your chosen policy provides an appropriate level of cover for your business and that you understand any requirements.

Infrastructure and property

- ☐ Identify any problem areas and potential flood heights affecting your business property.
- ☐ Ensure your business premises are well maintained and store items appropriately:
 - consider the potential for flooding when storing items around the office or other buildings, and identify high points for stacking and storing
 - secure objects that are likely to float and cause damage
 - store hazardous materials in waterproof containers in a secure cupboard to prevent leakage
 - store your equipment on a high shelf, in a plastic container where it can be protected.
- ☐ Consider making changes to your business buildings/property to protect against flood:
 - consider installing flood-proofing devices
 - set up your business in a building that has flood resistant floor coverings, furniture and fittings which are easily cleaned and less likely to be damaged (e.g. tiled floors on the ground level, raised electrical sockets).
- ☐ Check that your evacuation plan includes instructions to turn off electricity, gas and water at the mains in the event of a flood.

Emergencies

- ☐ For emergency help in flood call the NSW SES on **132 500**. For life-threatening emergencies call Triple Zero (**000**).
- ☐ Keep yourself, your staff and guests updated by checking the Bureau of Meteorology website bom.gov.au

Storm preparation checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan, to prepare your business for storms and severe weather.

Storms can bring strong winds, intense rainfall and hail. Strong winds and hail may damage your property and assets, and heavy rainfall can cause flooding, or flash flooding, which may result in road closures and staff absences.

Use this checklist to prepare your business and plan for disruptions due to storms and severe weather. See the NSW State Emergency Service (NSW SES) website for further information ses.nsw.gov.au. To view all current NSW storm and weather warnings visit the Bureau of Meteorology website bom.gov.au

General

- ☐ Include risk mitigation strategies for storms in your Business Continuity Plan. Information on emergency planning can be accessed on the NSW SES website ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare.
- ☐ Think about your insurance needs in relation to storms and make sure your chosen policy provides an appropriate level of cover for your business and that you understand any requirements.

Infrastructure and property

- ☐ Do general maintenance around your business premises and store items appropriately:
 - get your roof checked to make sure it is in good condition, and repair any damage
 - trim tree branches overhanging your roof. Check with your local council first to see if you require any permits or consent.
 - repair any corrosion, loose fittings and/or rotting timber
 - clear or secure any loose items that could cause damage if blown around in high winds (e.g. outdoor furniture, potted plants). Clear gutters, drains and downpipes so that water can drain away quickly
 - store hazardous materials in waterproof containers in a secure cupboard.
- ☐ If you live in a flood prone area, consider making changes to your business property to protect against flood. See the Flood Preparation Checklist for more information.
- ☐ Ensure you have enough stock on hand to supply your business and customers in the event of severe storm damage.

Prepare for power outages

- ☐ Check that your evacuation plan includes instructions to turn off electricity, in the event of a storm. Avoid using landline phones in the event of a storm.
- ☐ Ensure you and any key staff know how to manually override electronic access to your business or garage.
- ☐ Keep a contact number for your energy retailer or distributor in an accessible location. Call this number if you have an electrical fault or notice sparks from nearby powerlines.
- ☐ Consider alternative power supplies for your business in the event of an outage. Note that portable generators should be used with extreme caution and back-up generators should not be plugged into your switchboard.

Emergencies

- ☐ For emergency help during storms call the NSW SES on **132 500**. For life-threatening emergencies call Triple Zero (**000**).
- ☐ To report faults, hazards, or any electrical emergency, contact your energy retailer or distributor.
- ☐ Stay away from fallen powerlines and report them to NSW SES or Fire and Rescue NSW.
- ☐ Keep yourself, your staff and guests updated by checking the Bureau of Meteorology website bom.gov.au

Structure fire prevention checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan, to prepare your business in the event of a structure fire.

Employers have a duty of care to employees and visitors when they are on your property or undertaking a service provided by your business. Use this checklist to help assess whether you are adequately prepared for a structure fire. See the Fire and Rescue NSW website for further information and resources. Go to [fire.nsw.gov.au](https://www.fire.nsw.gov.au).

General

- ☐ Include risk mitigation strategies for storms in your Business Continuity Plan. Information on emergency planning can be accessed on the NSW SES website www.ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/business-emergency-planning.
- ☐ Think about your insurance needs in relation to storms and make sure your chosen policy provides an appropriate level of cover for your business and that you understand any requirements.
- ☐ Ensure your business has an adequately serviced and functional fire alarm system that is suitable for your small business, e.g. remote serviced alarm systems, sprinkler systems, thermal or smoke alarms.
- ☐ Write an emergency evacuation plan for how people should evacuate the workplace and where they should assemble if there is an emergency. Display the emergency evacuation plan where everyone can see it and practice your plan with your workers every six months. If you are in a multi-tenanted building, make sure the building manager will run practice evacuations for all tenants as part of your lease arrangements.
- ☐ Fire extinguishers should be located in a obvious, readily accessible location. Fire and Rescue NSW recommends that a surrounding clearance of a minimum of 1,000mm be maintained around each extinguisher.
- ☐ Ensure installed fire equipment is suitable for specific fire risks at your workplace (e.g. foam or dry powder type extinguishers for fires that involve flammable liquids, carbon dioxide extinguishers for electrical fires).
- ☐ Install signage so people can find fire equipment quickly and identify what type of fire it can be used on.
- ☐ Workers who may have to use fire equipment should be trained in how to use it and know what type of fire extinguishers to use for different types of fires.
- ☐ Make sure fire equipment is regularly maintained.
- ☐ Make sure emergency exits are unlocked and not blocked.
- ☐ Prevent electrical fires by having a regular inspection and maintenance program. Do not overload power points and power boards and regularly check electrical equipment for damage and faults.
- ☐ Make sure all machinery is serviced as recommended by manufacturers and is kept clean. If possible, switch machinery off when the business is unattended.
- ☐ Avoid storing or stockpiling flammable materials (such as packaging materials or waste) where they could be accessed by the public, including areas immediately outside your business premises.

Restaurant fire safety

Restaurants, cafes and other eating establishments are workplaces that are at a high risk from fire. This is due to an environment with the potential of combustibles close to hot surfaces and open flames. The most common fires involve unattended cooking, overheating of cooking oil or fat, and the ignition of fatty residues within rangehoods and ducting.

- ☐ Train your staff in maintaining clear fire exits, workplace fire safety, evacuation procedures and to call Triple Zero (000) in an emergency.
- ☐ Maintain routine cleaning and inspection of kitchen rangehoods, ducting and grease fans. Approximately 80 per cent of food preparation establishments hire contractors to maintain grease filters.

- ☐ Disposal of combustible waste products must be included in your maintenance program, ensuring rubbish and recyclables are secured in appropriate containers with close-fitting lids.
- ☐ Ensure all cookers/fryers have thermostats fitted, are serviced and cleaned as recommended by manufacturers.
- ☐ Don't store combustible liquids under or near cookers/fryers or blocking exits.
- ☐ Ensure that all equipment is turned off when the business is unattended (this does not include gas pilot lights).
- ☐ It is recommended that larger cooking and food preparation facilities are protected by automatic wet chemical systems for their deep fryers. Wet chemical fire extinguishers and fire blankets should also supplement this system. This also applies to smaller facilities. Ensure that the appropriate fire extinguishers and fire blankets are installed in an easily accessible location and not near vats and hot plates. They must be in good working order and checked as per Australian Standards.

Chemicals and fuels

Keep an up-to-date list of all the chemicals and fuels at your workplace and a copy of the manufacturer's or importer's material safety data sheets (MSDS) for each product.

Refer to the MSDS for information on how to safely use and store the product, how it can affect your health, first aid measures and any personal protective equipment that may need to be worn.

- ☐ Store incompatible chemicals and fuels separately.
- ☐ Store chemicals in a dedicated, well-ventilated storage area.
- ☐ Use bunding to capture any spills or leaks.
- ☐ Make sure all chemicals and fuels are clearly labelled.
- ☐ Do not store chemicals and fuels in empty food and drink containers.
- ☐ Make sure lids are secured on containers of chemicals and fuels.
- ☐ Keep flammable chemicals and fuels away from ignition sources (anything that can cause a spark or a flame such as power points, machines or equipment).
- ☐ Display signs outside your workplace if you store certain quantities of dangerous goods.
- ☐ Purchase smaller quantities and safer chemicals (e.g. granular products instead of dusty powders, water-based products instead of solvent based, more diluted chemicals).
- ☐ Minimise spills and splashes by using safe pouring or decanting techniques.
- ☐ Ensure spill-absorbent material is available to safely clean up spills.
- ☐ Use local exhaust ventilation to extract/capture dust, fumes or vapours away from the operator.
- ☐ Train supervisors, workers, contractors and first aiders in procedures for accidental consumption, splashes, spill contamination or other chemical or fuel emergencies.
- ☐ Dispose of any chemical or fuels you don't use anymore (contact your local council, local tip, chemical waste disposal company).
- ☐ Provide personal protective equipment (PPE) such as gloves, face shields, safety glasses or respirators if necessary and make sure PPE is used, cleaned and maintained properly.

Emergencies

If you see fire or smoke, do not panic or shout. Remain calm – remember RACE.

- ☐ RESCUE – Rescue any people in immediate danger (only if it is safe to do so).
- ☐ ALARM – Raise the alarm – call **000**.
- ☐ CONTAIN – If practicable, close all doors and windows to contain the fire (only if it safe to do so).
- ☐ EXTINGUISH – Try to extinguish the fire using appropriate fire-fighting equipment only if you are trained and it is safe to do so.

Pandemic preparation checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan to prepare your business for pandemics.

A pandemic is an epidemic of infectious disease that spreads through human populations across a large region. Like COVID-19, a pandemic could build up over time and would affect whole populations, with potentially high levels of illness, deaths and social and economic disruption.

Use this checklist to prepare your business in advance and take action to reduce potential impacts from a pandemic. See the NSW Health website for major updates and to view any public health orders and restrictions: health.nsw.gov.au. For support for businesses, including information on any available relief packages and financial and practical assistance, contact Service NSW on **13 77 88**, visit service.nsw.gov.au/business or download the Service NSW app.

General

- ☐ Consider the risk of a pandemic to your business. Likely impacts include staff absences and disruptions to supply chains, services and resources that your business relies on.
- ☐ Include risk mitigation strategies for pandemic in your Business Continuity Plan, including strategies to mitigate the financial impacts from ongoing reduced consumer spending and investment confidence during a pandemic.
- ☐ Consider your insurance needs in relation to a pandemic (e.g. loss of income). Make sure your chosen policy provides an appropriate level of cover for your business and that you understand any requirements.
- ☐ If your business has changed the way it operates, check that you have the necessary approvals, licences and/or permits in place. Contact Service NSW for more information, but you may also need to reach out to your local council.
- ☐ For personalised guidance on government services and support and to access a range of free videos, podcasts, articles and tools, visit service.nsw.gov.au/business. The NSW Government also offers vocational education and training (VET) through Skills NSW. Please visit skills.education.nsw.gov.au for more information.

Financial

- ☐ Keeping business records and managing cash flow can help you understand your financial position. Make strategic decisions or respond to challenges to keep your business resilient. Seek advice from your accountant or other financial professional.
- ☐ Check your eligibility for a tax deferral by speaking with your tax advisor or visit the ATO website ato.gov.au.
- ☐ Your business may be eligible to receive government support. Don't just rely on your own self-assessment of your eligibility, contact Service NSW for assistance. There may also be support available through your local council.
- ☐ If your business has been disrupted, you may wish to discuss this with your bank/lender, insurance provider and/or utility providers for any available financial hardship support. The earlier you do this, the more options there are available.

Infrastructure and property

- ☐ If you have a commercial lease, contact Service NSW to discuss any questions you may have about rent reduction, rent deferral or contract/lease termination.
- ☐ Consider holding a six-week supply of hand hygiene products (including alcohol-based hand gel), tissues and no-touch rubbish bins for staff and client/customer use during a pandemic.
- ☐ Consider purchasing a six-week supply of face masks for use during a pandemic by staff who may have ongoing close contact (within two metres) with people at work (note, education on the appropriate use of face masks is essential to avoid unintended negative consequences).
- ☐ Consider purchasing and maintaining technology and equipment (e.g. laptops, mobile phones, video-conferencing equipment) to support flexible and alternative work arrangements during a pandemic where feasible.

Staff and business visitors

- ☐ Keep customers updated about your trading situation. Communicate early with your customers so they are aware of any changes that will impact your services. Visit the Australian Competition and Consumer Commission (ACCC) website accc.gov.au for information on consumer obligations and how to manage cancellations, delays or suspension of products and services.
- ☐ Ensure your staff and guests are aware of pandemic procedures and their roles, including knowing the trigger for pandemic plans and how this information will be communicated.
- ☐ Ensure your staff and guests know where to access official sources of information during a pandemic (e.g. the NSW Health and Service NSW websites). Advice is likely to change quickly, especially in the early days as information about the new virus and how it behaves becomes available.
- ☐ Understand your obligations as an employer. For information about your ongoing responsibilities for work, health and safety (WHS) and workers compensation, visit the SafeWork NSW website safework.nsw.gov.au. For information on your workplace entitlements and obligations during a pandemic, visit the Fair Work Ombudsman website fairwork.gov.au.
- ☐ Identify ways to support staff health and wellbeing during a pandemic; this may include providing access to counselling services and supporting employees who are ill or in quarantine during a pandemic.
- ☐ Support your staff to follow the latest health advice regarding vaccinations for viruses like influenza and COVID-19.
- ☐ If you have staff who may be at higher risk of health complications from a virus and who have ongoing close contact (within two metres) with clients at work, consider assigning alternative duties for the duration of a pandemic.
- ☐ Reconsider the need for staff to provide medical certificates to access paid sick leave during a pandemic. There will be high demand for doctors' appointments during a pandemic and GP clinics will also be affected by staff absenteeism.
- ☐ Consider the effect of unusually high rates of absences could have on your business over an extended number of months and determine minimum staffing levels needed to maintain normal service delivery or production levels.
- ☐ Minimise key person dependency. Identify key positions and responsibilities and ensure other staff are trained to cover these roles as necessary. Maintain step-by-step guides for essential processes and procedures. Your Business Continuity Plan will help you with this.

In the event of a pandemic, keep yourself, your staff and guests updated by checking the NSW Health website health.nsw.gov.au and Service NSW website service.nsw.gov.au/business. The public health response to a pandemic involves state, national and international agencies, such as the World Health Organization with the Commonwealth Department of Health and the NSW Ministry of Health.

Tsunami preparation checklist

Use this checklist, along with your Business Continuity Plan, to prepare your business for tsunami.

A tsunami is a series of waves and can cause inundation and destruction when it hits land. There is a moderate likelihood of tsunami in NSW compared with other parts of the world.

For information, links and resources on preparing for, responding to and recovering from tsunami, visit the NSW State Emergency Service (NSW SES) website ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/tsunami

General

- ☐ Consider whether tsunami are a risk to your business. Include risk mitigation strategies for tsunami in your Business Continuity Plan.

Tsunami watches and warnings

- ☐
 - Tsunami Watches and Warnings are issued by the Bureau of Meteorology – bom.gov.au/resources/learn-and-explore/tsunami-knowledge-centre
 - Tsunami Warnings can be No Threat, Marine and Immediate Foreshore Threat or Land Inundation Threat

Natural warning signs

- ☐ In Australia you may receive an official Tsunami Warning, however it is important to know the natural warning signs of tsunami. You may:
 - FEEL the earth shake. If you are near the ocean and you feel the ground shake, a strong earthquake may have occurred and possibly caused a tsunami. However, you may not feel the earth shake if the earthquake occurred a long way away.
 - SEE the ocean drop or recede. Before a tsunami arrives, the ocean level may (but not always) drop or recede dramatically before returning as a wall of water. If you notice that the water is disappearing, tell any staff and business visitors and prepare to move to higher ground.
 - HEAR an unusual roaring sound. If you hear a loud roaring sound from the ocean (a bit like an aeroplane or a train), tell any staff and business visitors. This sound may be heard before a tsunami arrives.

Where to go

- ☐ NSW SES has developed Tsunami Evacuation Area Maps (ses.nsw.gov.au/plan-and-prepare/tsunami/evacuation-map) for coastal locations of NSW. These maps are of evacuation zones from the coast and are NOT inundation areas. Use these maps to help you plan for a possible tsunami.
 - Find the safest evacuation route and identify any point where your evacuation route may be cut off
 - Plan for any evacuation needed by foot due to congestion on roads.

Who to call

- ☐ For emergency help, call the NSW SES on **132 500**
- ☐ Keep local emergency numbers handy (use your phone or wallet)
- ☐ In a life-threatening emergency, call **000** (triple zero).

6. Recovery and reopening steps

The process of recovery and reopening can seem overwhelming, particularly when you don't have a plan. Use these checklists to get started.

Damage assessment and clean-up

To support any future claims it is critical to thoroughly document and assess damage.

- ☐ Take photos and videos: Document all damage before beginning cleanup for insurance applications or other claims.
- ☐ Inspect all areas: Check the roof, walls, floors, electrical systems and plumbing for damage.
- ☐ Sort salvageable items: Identify what can be repaired, restored, or discarded and retrieve and secure any undamaged assets or equipment.
- ☐ Remove debris safely: Safety should remain front of mind when removing damaged stock and debris. Beware of hazardous materials and seek advice if unsure.
- ☐ Work with professionals to assess damage: Engage licensed electricians, plumbers, builders, and qualified surveyors or assessors to evaluate damage and repair costs.
- ☐ Consider temporary relocation: If necessary, identify alternative locations to resume business operations while repairs are underway.
- ☐ Coordinate with landlord (if leasing): Engage with your landlord as soon as possible as landlords and tenants are responsible for different costs depending on the lease.
- ☐ Check lease agreements: Review clauses related to rent abatement, repair responsibilities and lease termination options.

Business reopening and operations

Planning a structured return to business ensures smoother operations.

- ☐ Develop a reopening plan: Prioritise repairs, stock replenishment and customer communication.
- ☐ Adjust business model: Consider temporary alternative locations, online sales or modified services.
- ☐ Communicate with stakeholders: Keep customers, suppliers and employees informed of reopening plans.
- ☐ Reestablish supply chains: Work with vendors to resume deliveries and secure essential inventory.
- ☐ Ensure workplace safety: Verify that all repairs meet health and safety standards before reopening.
- ☐ Review compliance requirements: Check with local councils or industry regulators to confirm any new compliance measures before resuming operations.

Long-term recovery and preparedness

Update your recovery plan, invest in infrastructure improvements and ensure financial preparedness. Engage with business networks and government agencies for ongoing support.

For more detailed guidance: Guides to help you prepare for and recover from disaster

(<https://www.smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/help/common-questions/get-ready-for-disasters>)



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Phone: **1300 795 534**

Web: smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/contact-us

Address: **4 Parramatta Square, 12 Darcy St Parramatta NSW 2150**

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